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80 |

Our mass prosperity is held back by wages rather than jobs, high wages are held back by a shortage of non-farm employers with high productivity

also hinders the government's ability to sniff out defaults, delays and frauds for effective enforcement.

The proposed PAN 2.0 will serve as a unique enterprise identifier; it should instantly be adopted by the central government, with state governments getting a time-bound glide path. The enterprise Aadhaar (PAN 2.0) should be followed by enterprise DigiLocker —a secure digital repository for all government-issued licences, registrations, and permissions. A single source of truth, this tamper-proof, authenticated, and credible repository would reduce approval and compliance cycles from months to days.

The rationalisation reform vector is complicated since it now equates with civil service reform. Our 25 million civil servants have shifted from a steel frame to a steel cage because of thought worlds like prohibited till permitted, guilty till innocent, drunk driving is an argument against cars and the tendency to be too small for big things and too big for small things. In 1748, the political philosopher Montesquieu

posited that laws must exhibit consistency and called their underlying relationships the 'Spirit of Laws'. The prevailing spirit underlying our economic laws is characterised by distrust. The rationalisation vector is most impactful at the state government level and offers Chief Ministers a non-fiscal tool to make their *karmabhoomi* a more fertile habitat for high wages.

The decriminalising reform vector must accept that the meagre outcomes of Jan Vishwas 1.0 (only 50 central government employer jail provisions removed) arose from asking bureaucrats to cut the tree they are sitting on. Jan Vishwas 2.0 must remove all jail provisions that don't fit five clear criteria: physical harm to other individuals, intentional defrauding of stakeholders, externalities to societies so large that the violator cannot compensate, no jail provisions in general clauses that define the crime too broadly or do not specify the crime, and no jail provisions related to delayed and inaccurate filings, procedural infractions, incorrect calculations, and wrong formats. These five criteria eliminate almost half of the more than 5,000 central government jail provisions and create a template for the over 20,000 state government jail provisions.

India's employed poverty challenges arise from a sense of humour about the rule of law that gives us too many people on farms, too many people in self-employment, too few people in manufacturing, and too few high productivity employers. Nobel Prize economist Daniel Kahneman suggested we instinctively step on the accelerator to go faster, but often better results come from taking our foot off the brake. He was talking about many things but one of them was India's regulatory cholesterol. **BT**

Views are personal